To put the BJP's rise in the Northeast in perspective, it is important to underscore the low base it started from. In Tripura, until a few weeks before the March 2018 assembly election, the party did not have even a councillor-level elected representative. It won zero seats (1.5 per cent votes) in the 2013 assembly polls. To go from that to bagging thirty-five of sixty assembly seats and 43 per cent of vote share in 2018 was an astonishing feat, especially in a largely tribal state. Only AAP in Delhi in 2013 and NTR's TDP in Andhra in the early 1980s offer comparable political start-up stories. But they were new formations, unknown quantities. The BJP, on the other hand, has been a known ideological entity in the Northeast for decades, working closely with the RSS's grassroots outreach in the region. In Tripura, the BJP won not only Congress bastions—the urban areas around Agartala—but also Left strongholds: huge swathes of forested tribal areas across south, central and eastern Tripura (see Figure 16.2).[16] It had a similar growth spurt pattern in Assam. The best that the party had ever performed before the 2016 showing was in 2006: ten seats (12 per cent vote share) in Assam's 126-member assembly. From there, it grew by 500 per cent, catapulting to sixty seats (29.8 per cent vote share) in 2016. It repeated this feat after five years in power, winning 60 seats again (33.21 per cent vote share) in 2021 (see Figure 16.3). Similarly, in Arunachal Pradesh, the BJP accelerated from eleven seats (30.97 per cent vote share) in 2014 to forty-one (50.86 per cent votes) in the 2019 provincial polls. In Manipur, it went from a previous best of four seats in 2002 to twenty-one in 2017 (36.29 per cent votes); and in Nagaland, from a previous best of seven seats (10.8 per cent vote share) in 2002 to twelve (15.3 per cent votes) in 2018 (see Appendices 11–14).

Figure 16.2: The BJP's Stunning Rise in Tripura